

Day 3 — Rivers as Sacred

Module: Indic Ecology — Vasudhaiva Kuṭumbakam · **Band:** Senior · **Time:** 45 min

Learning objective

By the end of this lesson, students will: discuss the ecological function of river-worship traditions.

Materials

- Whiteboard / chart paper
- Notebook, pen per student
- (See lesson-plan.md for any day-specific materials)

Vocabulary introduced today

- *ahimsā* (IAST: *ahimsā*; lit. “non-violence; extended to non-human life”)

Lesson flow

Warm-up (5 min)

- Daily check-in: one-sentence response to “*What’s one thing you remember about yesterday’s lesson?*”
- Hook: introduce a phenomenon or question that motivates today’s concept.

Core (20 min)

1. **The Indian river tradition.** *Gaṅgā, Yamunā, Sarasvatī, Narmadā, Kāverī, Godāvarī, Sindhu* — seven sacred rivers in Hindu tradition. Each has festival cycles, pilgrimage routes, ritual practices.
2. **The ecological function of sacredness.** Treating a river as sacred → norms against pollution, against blocking the flow, against over-extraction. *In principle*. These norms are NOT always honoured today (Ganga, Yamuna are heavily polluted).
3. **Modern parallel.** Ecuador and Bolivia have laws giving rivers legal personhood. Aotearoa/New Zealand granted legal personhood to the Whanganui River in 2017. India’s Ganga and Yamuna were granted similar status briefly in 2017 (court ruling overturned). The legal innovation echoes the older sacred-river framing.
4. **Source.** Atharva Veda Pṛthivī Sūkta 12.1 — multiple references to flowing waters. Vedic hymns to *āpaḥ* (waters). Bhāgavata Purāṇa discusses the seven rivers.
5. **Critical look.** “*Why are sacred-river norms often violated in practice today? What changes in society have weakened the older protections? Can the framework be revived for the climate crisis?*”

Activity (15 min)

A scaled version of *Sacred Grove (or Local Ecology) Mapping* (see [activities/](#)). Today's slice: focus on the part of the activity that reinforces Rivers as Sacred.

Wrap-up (5 min)

- One-sentence exit ticket: “*What’s one thing you learned today?*”
- Preview tomorrow.

Homework

(See [homework.md](#) for today’s task.)

Differentiation

- **Extension:** offer one open question or extra problem for fast finishers.
- **Support:** pair students who need scaffolds; offer partial outlines.

Teacher notes

- Citations: at least one quoted verse with citation per module. Day 1 already includes one if applicable; you may add more.
- Connect to prior modules where natural (especially Module 2 *pañcabhūta*).